

Elizabeth Means

Haslett, MI · hi@elizabethmeans.com
elizabethmeans.com · linkedin.com/in/elizabeth-a-means · github.com/emeans

Professional Summary

Cross-functional leader who operates across the full stack of what makes teams and products work: delivery, design, and the people practices that sustain both. Spent a decade as an engineer consistently operating at the design-engineering intersection before stepping fully into product and design leadership. Most recently led 0-to-1 development of a licensable WIC management information system: owning product vision and delivery for a cross-functional team that grew from 4 to 10 with zero attrition, while leading hands-on UX design across 30+ feature sets and building design operations infrastructure from scratch. Co-founded a 45-member internal design community. SHRM-certified people manager. Completing UX Research & Design certification, University of Michigan.

SKILLS

Product & Delivery: Product Strategy, Agile/Scrum (10+ years), Roadmap Prioritization, Requirements Analysis, Stakeholder Management, Cross-functional Delivery, Jira, Confluence

Design & Research: UX Design, User Research, Information Architecture, Wireframing, Prototyping, Design Systems, Figma, Accessibility (WCAG 2.2, Section 508), UX Writing

People & Culture: Team Development, Psychological Safety, Culture Building, Delegation Frameworks, Onboarding Design, SHRM People Manager Qualification

Technical: TypeScript, JavaScript, Angular, HTML, CSS/Sass, REST APIs, Git, Storybook

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

WIC Product Manager | Kunz, Leigh & Associates | 2023 – 2026

- Led 0-to-1 development of a licensable WIC management information system targeting U.S. state and tribal WIC programs. A participant-first, human-centered platform built as a competitive alternative to legacy incumbents. Owned product vision, requirements, and delivery across a 10-person cross-functional team.
- Drove product decisions through sustained discovery: 40+ sessions with internal subject matter experts, focus groups with WIC staff across 3 states, and 5 National WIC Association conferences as the primary validation channel. Discovery informed 30+ distinct feature sets over two years.
- Led hands-on UX design across 100+ high-fidelity Figma prototypes. Applied usability heuristics systematically: information architecture that follows users' mental models, recognition over recall, plain-language microcopy treated as core design work rather than an afterthought.
- Cultivated psychological safety and genuine ownership as the foundation for a team that grew from 4 to 10 with zero attrition, 2 promotions, and 2 engineers stepping into leadership over two years.
- Created design operations infrastructure from scratch as the team scaled, establishing shared defaults for research, handoff, delegation, and writing that gave the team a common language without mandating how to use it.

- \$14.9M in USDA-funded federal research independently validated the product architecture, describing the ideal modern WIC platform as participant-first, human-centered, modular, and licensable, the exact principles on which it was built.
- First and only recipient of the Triple Crown Award, a peer-nominated recognition created by the company to honor an unprecedented number of nominations across all three core values: excellence and growth, investing in people, and building trust.

Staff Software Engineer | Kunz, Leigh & Associates | 2022 – 2023

- Established an in-code Storybook component library with integrated ADA compliance tooling, connecting design decisions to living code, and making accessibility part of the build process rather than a retrofit.
- Operated as the design voice within an 8-person engineering team: partnered with business analysts on experience decisions, advocated for user needs in technical trade-offs, and mentored junior developers on translating ambiguous requirements into deliberate, user-grounded decisions.

Lead Software Engineer | Kunz, Leigh & Associates | 2020 – 2022

- Managed and mentored a team of 4 developers with 3 promotions to senior positions through structured 1:1s focused on career trajectory and deliberate stretch assignments.
- Modernized the MAEAP environmental verification system using monorepo architecture, replacing manual tracking processes and enabling state verifiers to efficiently manage compliance across 5,000+ farms.

Full Stack Engineer | Kunz, Leigh & Associates | 2015 – 2020

- Co-built a company-wide shared component library and introduced Angular as the primary frontend framework, now adopted as the standard across 10+ projects.

ADDITIONAL LEADERSHIP

Design Group Co-Founder & Contributor | Kunz, Leigh & Associates | 2019 – 2026

- Co-founded and chartered an internal design community that grew to 45+ active members. Developed through consistent education and shared ownership rather than a top-down mandate. Originated 10+ articles on UX principles that became a lasting shared reference across the company, personally authoring and publishing 5.

CERTIFICATIONS

People Manager Qualification | 2021

Society for Human Resource Management (SHRM)

UX Research & Design Certificate | Est. 2026

University of Michigan

EDUCATION

Bachelor of Science, Computer Science | 2012 – 2015

Michigan Technological University